



Understanding Therapeutic Plasma Exchange (TPE)

Therapeutic plasma exchange (TPE) is a treatment that removes plasma from your blood. The removed plasma is then replaced with a substitute. Plasma is the liquid part of blood. It helps carry blood cells and other substances all over your body. With certain diseases, plasma can contain an abnormal substance that may trigger symptoms. TPE helps remove this abnormal substance and ease symptoms. TPE can also help you better fight your disease. TPE is also known as plasmapheresis.

Why TPE is done

TPE is most often used to treat certain blood, nervous system, or autoimmune diseases. Examples are:

- ◆ Thrombotic thrombocytopenic purpura (TTP)
- ◆ Guillain-Barré syndrome
- ◆ Certain types of multiple sclerosis
- ◆ Chronic inflammatory demyelinating polyradiculoneuropathy (CIDP)
- ◆ Lambert-Eaton syndrome
- ◆ Myasthenia gravis
- ◆ Some diseases of the kidney such as Goodpasture syndrome
- ◆ Waldenström macroglobulinemia. This is a rare type of non-Hodgkin lymphoma.

Used alone, TPE can't cure these diseases. But it may help slow their progress and ease symptoms. When used with other treatments, TPE may increase your chances of fighting the disease.

How TPE is done

TPE uses a special machine to separate blood into its different parts. It then removes and replaces most of the plasma. You often need more than one treatment. You and your healthcare provider will discuss the schedule for your treatment in advance. Each plasma exchange takes about 2 to 4 hours.